

Incident Lifecycle Automation in ServiceNow

PHASE 1: IDEATION

Project Detail	Information
Domain	Information Technology
Project Type	Individual Project
Platform	ServiceNow
Primary Area	IT Service Management (ITSM)
Project Scenario	Corporate VPN incident lifecycle from creation to resolution

Prepared as part of the seven-phase project documentation

1. Phase Overview

The ideation phase explains how the project idea was identified and why it is worth solving. The starting point for this project was a simple observation: an IT incident may look small to the person who reports it, but the work behind that incident can involve several teams, multiple records, repeated communication, technical investigation, and sometimes a change to the IT environment. When these activities are handled inconsistently, the user experiences delay and the support team spends extra time coordinating the work.

For this project, the selected scenario is a Corporate VPN connectivity or authentication issue. A VPN problem is a useful example because remote employees depend on secure access to internal resources, and a single incident can involve a service desk analyst, a network support team, a configuration item, knowledge articles, change management, a related or child incident, and SLA tracking. This makes the scenario realistic enough to demonstrate the complete incident lifecycle in ServiceNow.

2. Brainstorming and Opportunity Discovery

The brainstorming activity focused on everyday problems that can occur when incident handling depends too heavily on manual decisions. The purpose was not to assume that every organization has the same problem, but to identify common areas where a structured ServiceNow process can make support work clearer and more traceable.

- An incident may be assigned to a team that does not own the affected technology, which creates avoidable reassignment and delay.
- Support agents may search for previous fixes manually even when useful knowledge already exists in the system.
- If several users face the same underlying issue, separate incidents may be investigated independently instead of being linked.
- A technical fix may require a controlled change, but the relationship between the incident and the change can be lost if both processes are handled separately.
- Important updates can remain in informal conversations instead of being recorded in the incident activity history.
- The resolution may solve the immediate issue but fail to create reusable knowledge, which means the same troubleshooting effort may be repeated later.
- SLA status and related records can be difficult to review when the incident process is fragmented.

After comparing these ideas, the project direction became clear: build and demonstrate a structured incident lifecycle in ServiceNow where the incident is created, classified, supported with knowledge, reassigned when necessary, investigated by Level 2 support, connected to change management when required, linked with a child incident for a related user, resolved with proper notes, and converted into reusable knowledge.

3. Problem Statement

IT support teams need a dependable way to move an incident from the first user report to a verified resolution. When classification, assignment, escalation, knowledge usage, change handling, and resolution documentation are performed inconsistently, the organization can face slower restoration of service, repeated troubleshooting, poor visibility, and weak traceability. The problem addressed by this project is therefore the lack of a single, structured incident lifecycle that connects the major ITSM activities required to resolve an issue efficiently.

Formal problem statement: Develop an Incident Lifecycle Automation solution in ServiceNow that standardizes incident creation, classification, knowledge assistance, assignment, escalation, investigation, change linkage, related incident handling, resolution, knowledge creation, and SLA validation so that incidents can be managed in a more consistent and traceable manner.

4. Target Users and Stakeholders

Stakeholder	What they need from the process
End user / employee	A simple way to report the problem, timely progress updates, and confidence that the issue is being handled by the right team.
Service Desk analyst	Clear incident information, relevant knowledge, correct classification fields, and a predictable path for escalation.
Network / Level 2 technician	Accurate technical context, service and CI information, previous work notes, and a way to record investigation and resolution.
Change team / approver	A clear reason for the change and a traceable relationship between the change and the incident that triggered it.
ServiceNow administrator / project owner	Consistent configuration, visible related records, and a process that can be tested end to end.

5. Empathy Map

The empathy map was created from the viewpoint of an employee who cannot connect to the Corporate VPN and a support analyst who is trying to restore the service. The intention is to understand both the emotional side of the incident and the operational needs of the support team.

Area	End-user perspective	Support-team perspective
Thinks	"I need access to my work resources. How long will this take?"	"Do I have enough information to diagnose this, and is it assigned to the correct team?"
Feels	Frustrated, blocked, and uncertain when remote work depends on VPN access.	Responsible for restoring service quickly while following the correct process.
Says	"I cannot connect to the Corporate VPN from home."	"I need the error details, affected service, CI information, and previous troubleshooting."
Does	Reports the incident, checks updates, and tries any approved workaround provided by support.	Classifies the incident, checks knowledge, updates notes, escalates when needed, and records resolution details.
Fears / pains	Long delays, repeated questions, lack of status information, and having to explain the same issue again.	Incorrect assignment, missing context, duplicated investigation, SLA risk, and incomplete documentation.
Gains	Faster restoration, clear status, consistent communication, and a dependable support experience.	Better traceability, reusable knowledge, cleaner handoffs, and a repeatable resolution process.

6. Proposed Solution Concept

The proposed solution is an end-to-end ServiceNow incident lifecycle centered on a Remote Access service and a Corporate VPN service offering. The incident is used as the main record that carries the issue through classification, knowledge assistance, team assignment, technical investigation, change linkage, child-incident creation, resolution, and validation. This keeps the story of the issue in one controlled process instead of scattering information across unrelated activities.

1. Create or identify the Remote Access business service and the Corporate VPN service offering.
2. Create a VPN connectivity or authentication incident and capture the relevant incident details.
3. Classify the incident using fields such as category, subcategory, urgency, service, service offering, and configuration item.
4. Use Agent Assist or knowledge search to check whether an existing article can support initial troubleshooting.
5. Reassign or escalate the incident from the Service Desk to the Network team when Level 2 investigation is required.
6. Create and link an emergency change when the technical resolution requires a controlled change to the environment.
7. Create a child incident when another user is affected by the same problem and the records should be related.
8. Record probable cause, work notes, and resolution information, then resolve the incident.
9. Create a knowledge article from the verified solution and review related records and SLA information as part of final validation.

7. Value Proposition

The value of the project comes from connecting several ITSM practices into one understandable flow. Instead of presenting Incident Management, Knowledge Management, Change Management, and SLA tracking as separate topics, the project shows how they can support one another during a real support scenario. The result is a demonstration that is easier for a mentor to evaluate because each step has a clear reason and a visible relationship to the incident lifecycle.

- Improves consistency by giving support teams a repeatable path from incident creation to closure.
- Reduces avoidable searching by bringing knowledge into the troubleshooting process.
- Improves traceability by linking the incident with changes and related incidents.
- Encourages better resolution documentation and reusable knowledge.
- Makes final validation easier by checking status, relationships, and SLA information in one workflow.

8. Scope of the Idea

The project is intentionally scoped as an academic or demonstration implementation rather than a full enterprise rollout. The focus is the lifecycle and the relationships between ServiceNow records. Enterprise-scale integrations, organization-wide security design, production data migration, advanced analytics, and large-volume performance engineering are outside the current scope unless they are separately configured and demonstrated.

9. Ideation Deliverables

Deliverable	Purpose
-------------	---------

Brainstorming summary	Records the operational problems that motivated the project idea.
Problem statement	Defines the central challenge the project is designed to solve.
Stakeholder list	Identifies the people who interact with or depend on the incident lifecycle.
Empathy map	Captures user thoughts, feelings, fears, pains, and expected gains.
Proposed solution concept	Describes the ServiceNow lifecycle selected to address the problem.
Initial scope statement	Clarifies what the project will demonstrate and what is outside the current scope.

10. Phase Conclusion

The ideation phase establishes a practical reason for building the project. The selected VPN scenario is easy to understand from a user perspective while still being rich enough to demonstrate the major activities of IT incident handling. By the end of this phase, the project has a clear problem statement, identified users, an empathy map, a proposed solution, and a defined scope. These outputs become the foundation for the requirement analysis phase.